

BRONZE AGE



IN ABOUT 3000 BC, prehistoric people began to use bronze – an alloy of copper and tin – instead

of stone, to make weapons and ornaments. The dates for this development, which is known as the Bronze Age, vary from culture to culture, but the earliest bronze workers probably lived in Mesopotamia (modern Iraq). These people initially used pure gold and copper, which were easy to hammer into shape, before discovering how to make bronze. They were also responsible for developing the world's first civilizations. The Bronze Age was followed by a time when people learned to smelt and shape iron ore to produce stronger tools and weapons. This period is known as the Iron Age.

Making bronze

People learned how to extract metal from ores by heating the rock. The metal could then be used to make useful or decorative objects.

Ore

This common type of copper ore was fairly easy for people to spot on the ground.

Yellow chalcocite

Blue bornite

Smelting

To extract the metal, Bronze Age people heated the ore to a high temperature. When the metal in the ore reached melting point, they collected it in a round, stone crucible.

Casting

Bronze Age people cast objects by pouring hot, molten bronze into a mould. When the metal had cooled and set, the mould was opened, revealing the finished item. Casting was used to produce decorative items.

Molten metal was poured through holes.

The mould was carved to the shape of the item.



Cast pin

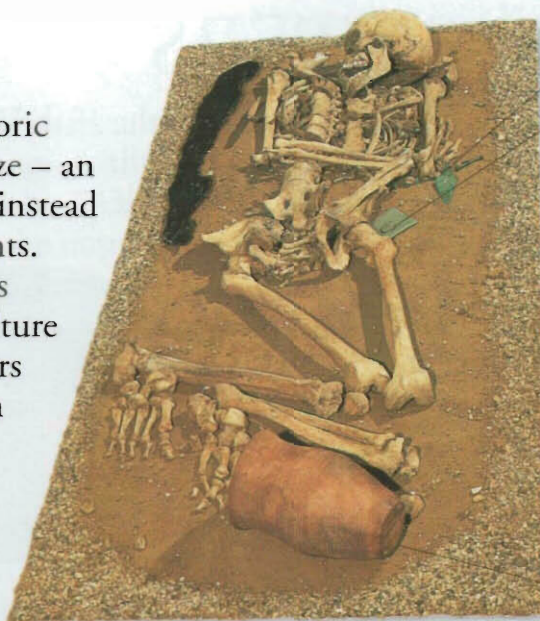
Stone mould

Mould

This is one half of a stone mould for casting pins. It was made in Switzerland, c.1000 BC. To use the mould, the two halves were fastened together, and metal poured in through the holes at the top.

Cast pin

Bronze pins like this were cast in the stone mould. The mould used to make this pin was carved to create the delicate pattern on the pin-head.



Stone wristguard with gold screws

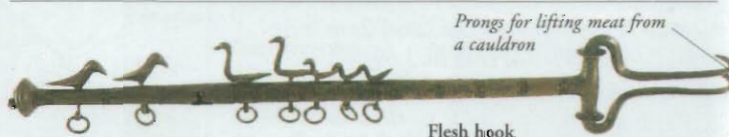
Copper dagger blade

The first metalworkers

In the early days of the Bronze Age, metalworkers used gold, copper, and bronze for luxury items, or for high-status weapons, such as the dagger in the Barnack grave, England. People still made tools from stone, because stone was harder than bronze.

Pottery beaker for use in the afterlife

The Barnack grave, c.1800 BC



Prongs for lifting meat from a cauldron

Flesh hook

Copper

The royal family of the city of Ur in Mesopotamia used copper for jewellery, as well as for everyday items, such as this flesh hook. They used gold to make beautiful vessels for special occasions.

Bronze swords were sometimes cast, although they were stronger when the bronze was beaten into shape. This Danish sword is polished to show the original golden colour of bronze.

Pins fastened clothing before buttons were invented

Bronze axe head

Bronze bangle

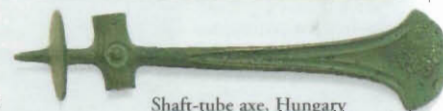
Bronze pendant

Danish bronze sword

Ornate French sword

Bronzeware

Bronze was prized for its beauty. In Europe, the nobles liked to wear bronze jewellery, such as bangles and pendants, and bronze pins in their clothing. Bronze swords were high-status weapons.



Shaft-tube axe, Hungary

1800 BC Bronze Age reaches European areas, such as modern Slovakia.

800 BC Early Iron Age starts in central Europe.

Timeline

3800 BC The earliest known metal objects are produced by smelting. Copper is the main metal smelted in Tepe Yahya, Iran.

3000 BC Bronze objects are used throughout western Asia, where copper is being combined with tin.

2500 BC Bronze is used in the cities of Mohenjo-Daro and Harappa, Indus Valley.

2000 BC Bronze-working comes to the civilizations of the Minoans on Crete and the Mycenaeans in mainland Greece. These Aegean cultures trade in Europe for copper and tin.

1900 BC Iron Age starts in western Asian areas such as Turkey, Iran, and Iraq.

Ingots

Early metalworkers discovered how to add molten tin to copper to make bronze. Liquid bronze was poured into round moulds and left to set. The blocks of bronze were called ingots.

Trace of an ingot

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